

Concerns about “AI-assisted analysis of $^{28}\text{Si} \rightarrow 7\alpha$ breakup data”

8/27/2025

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References

- Examination of evidence for resonances at high excitation energy in the 7α disassembly of ^{28}Si
 - X.G. Cao *et al.*
 - Phys. Rev. C **99**, 014606
- Experimental search for toroidal high-spin isomers in collisions of $^{28}\text{Si} + ^{12}\text{C}$ @ 35 MeV/nucleon with the Forward Array Using Silicon Technology
 - A. Hannaman, B. M. Harvey, *et al.*
 - Phys. Rev. C **109**, 054615
- Artificial-intelligence-assisted analysis of $^{28}\text{Si} \rightarrow 7\alpha$ breakup data
 - T. Depastas, A. Bonasera, and J. Natowitz
 - Phys. Rev. C **112**, 014614

Introduction to Common Themes

When is a peak consistent with a prediction?

Absolute difference?

Statistical significance?

What is the background?

Shape

Size

Confidence

Importance

Use of Polynomial

What does the fit represent?

What conclusions can be drawn from the fit?

Quality of Calibration

Are there detectable gain drifts?

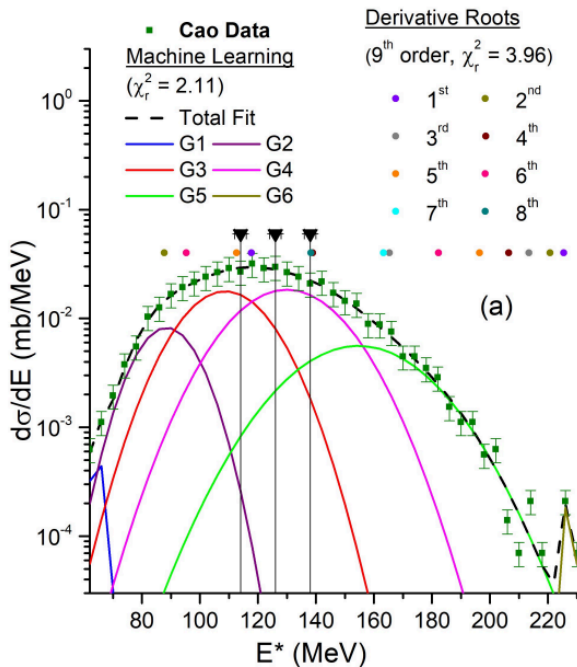
General Statistics

Independence of samples

Significance of deviations in spectra

Defintions of Consistency (and the implications on statistical significance)

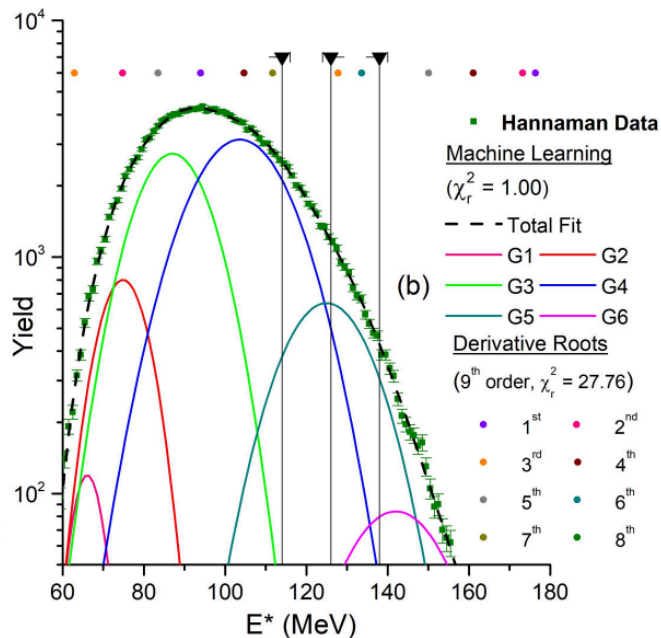
Application to Experimental Data



- “For the [Cao data] we obtain six peaks which approximately reproduce the predicted 114 MeV and 138 MeV toroid resonances (black triangles) in the region of high statistics. The peak at 126 MeV is not reproduced independently, but belongs to the wide fourth Gaussian.” — §4 par 1

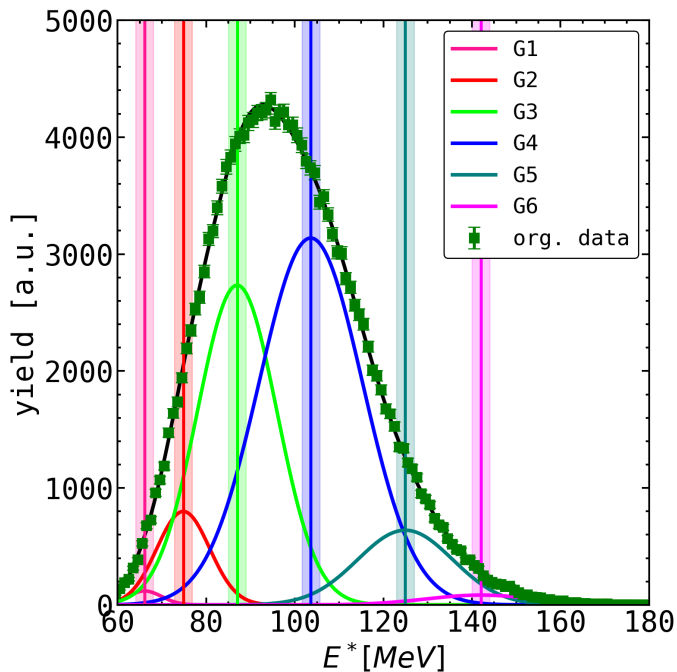
- 114 MeV: ~4 MeV away from G3
- 126 MeV: ~4 MeV away from G4
- 138 MeV: ~8 MeV away from G4

Application to Experimental Data



- “Interestingly, the resonances are close to the aforementioned found by Cao and collaborators.” — §4 par 1
- 114 MeV: ~10 MeV away from G4
- 126 MeV: ~1 MeV away from G5
- 138 MeV: ~4 MeV away from G6

Suppose 2 MeV Windows



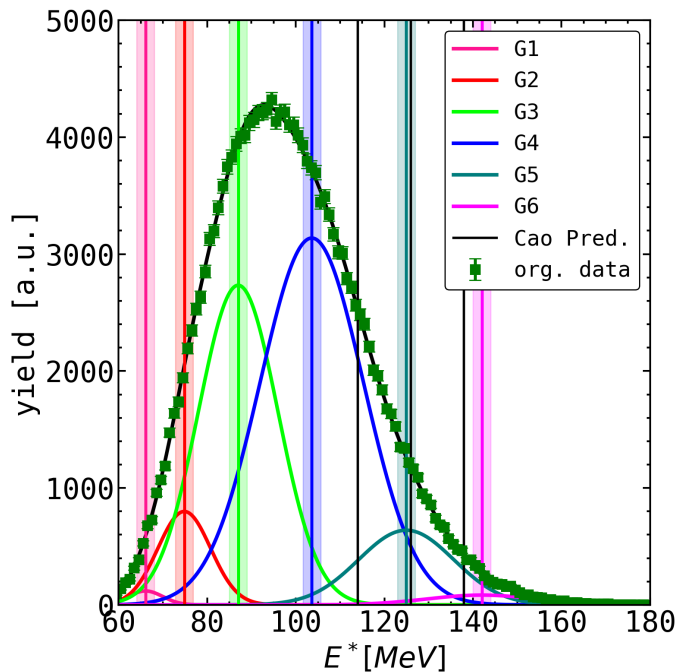
- Define “consistency” *before* looking at predictions

- “Any Gaussian that lands within x MeV of a prediction is said to be consistent with that prediction.”

- Ask : “How surprising is it if at least one out of three predictions is reproduced?”

$$\begin{aligned}
 P_{\geq 1|3} &= P(n_{\text{repro.}} \geq 1 \mid 3 \text{ pred.}) = 1 - \left[P(n_{\text{repro.}} = 0 \mid 1 \text{ pred.}) \right]^3 \\
 &\approx 1 - \left(\frac{120 - 24}{120} \right)^3 \\
 &= \boxed{48.8\%}
 \end{aligned}$$

Add in Cao Predictions



- A statistically unsurprising result:
 - One of the predictions was consistent with one of the Gaussians.

$$P_{=0|3} \approx 51.2\%$$

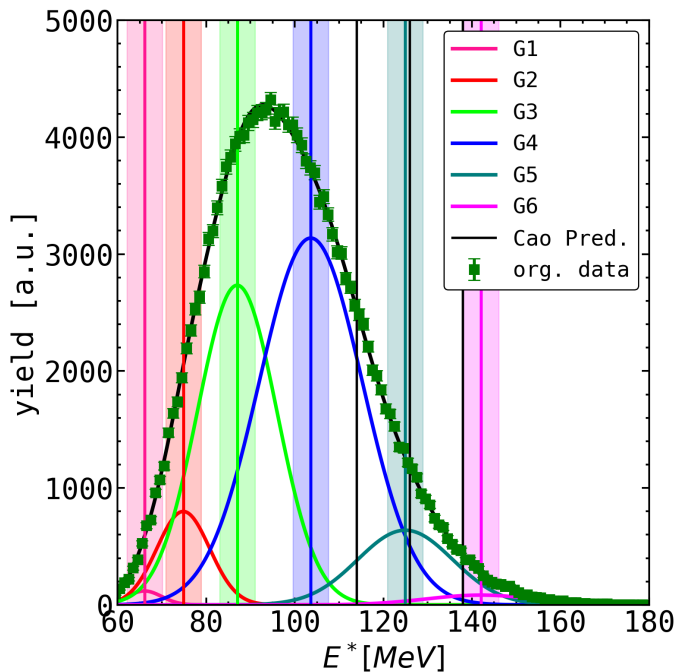
$$P_{=1|3} \approx 38.4\%$$

$$P_{=2|3} \approx 9.6\%$$

$$P_{=3|3} \approx 0.8\%$$

Maybe open the window?

Suppose 4 MeV Windows



- One or two peaks consistent
 - Neither result would be surprising

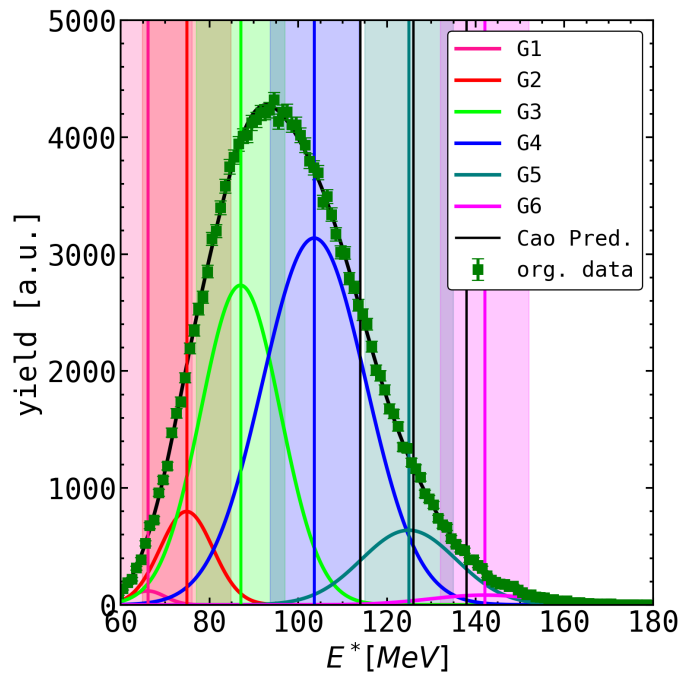
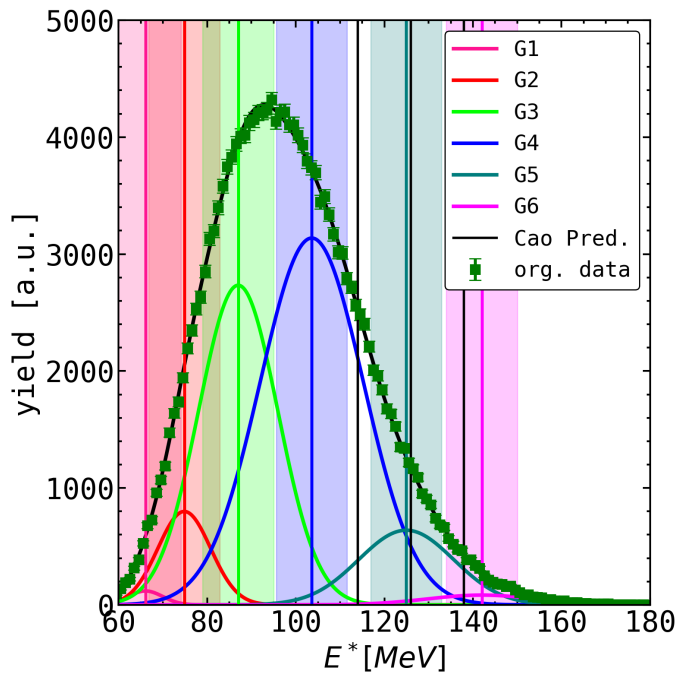
$$P_{=0|3} \approx 21.6\%$$

$$P_{=1|3} \approx 43.2\%$$

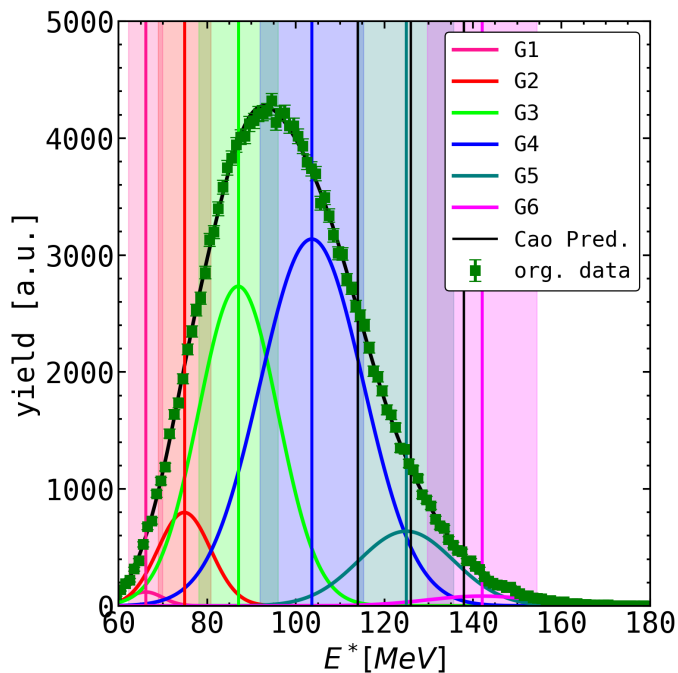
$$P_{=2|3} \approx 28.8\%$$

$$P_{=3|3} \approx 6.4\%$$

Suppose Very Wide Windows



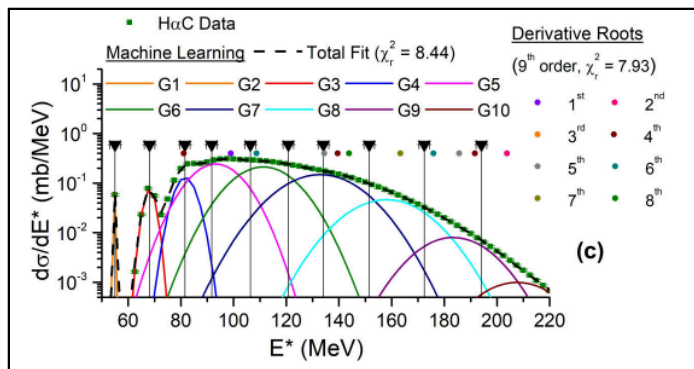
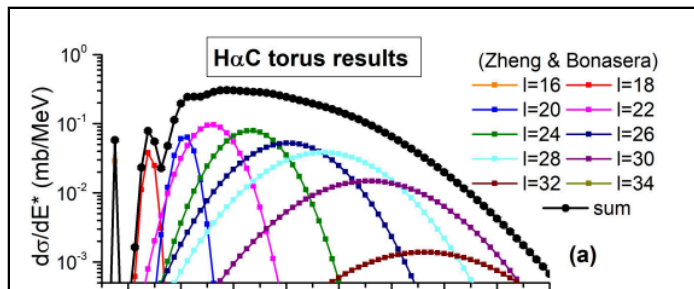
Use HWHM of Each Gaussian



It is challenging to have a definition of consistent/
close/reproducing which simultaneously shows
agreement of the GMM peaks and the Cao
predictions that is statistically significant

Shortcomings of the Chosen Benchmark

Degree of agreement



Using absolute deltas to line up Gaussians within 2 MeV

Correspond to obvious local maxima

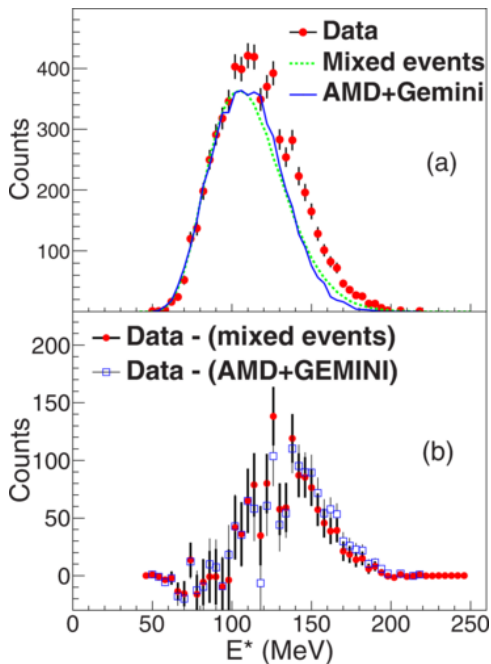
- G1 and G2 seem duplicated but within 1 MeV of $l = 16$
- G3 within 1 MeV with $l = 18$
- G4 within 1 MeV with $l = 20$

Do not correspond to obvious local maxima

- G5 is within ~ 1 – 2 MeV of $l = 22$
- G6 is within ~ 4 MeV of $l = 24$
- G7 is within ~ 1 MeV of $l = 26$
- G8 is within ~ 7 MeV of $l = 30$
- G9 is about 10 MeV off of $l = 30$ or $l = 32$
- G10 is > 10 MeV away from $l = 32$

- Without distinct features, GMM fails to reproduce overlapping contributions

Robustness of agreement in the presence of a background



- The background according to MD & mixed:
 - not Gaussian.
 - the dominant feature ($\gtrsim 90\%$) of the distribution.
- No background was included in the benchmark
- GMM assumes the underlying probability distribution is a sum of Gaussians
- The reliability of the GMM technique in the presence of an uncharacterized, but dominant, non-Gaussian background has *not* been demonstrated.

Discussion of the Polynomial Fit

We Are Looking for Prominent, Narrow Resonances

NIMROD

Si + CsI telescopes

High angular coverage ($\sim 85\%$ of 4π)

Neutron Ball

Position limited by detector size

~ 9.4 MeV (FWHM) 7α E^* resolution in ROI

Measured $\sim 6.5k$ 7α events

Claims possible peaks with measured FWHMs

- 5.88 MeV
- 8.57 MeV
- 8.03 MeV

FAUST

Si + CsI telescopes

Very forward focussed ($\sim 2^\circ - 25^\circ$ lab frame)

No neutron detection

Position only limited by DADL resolution

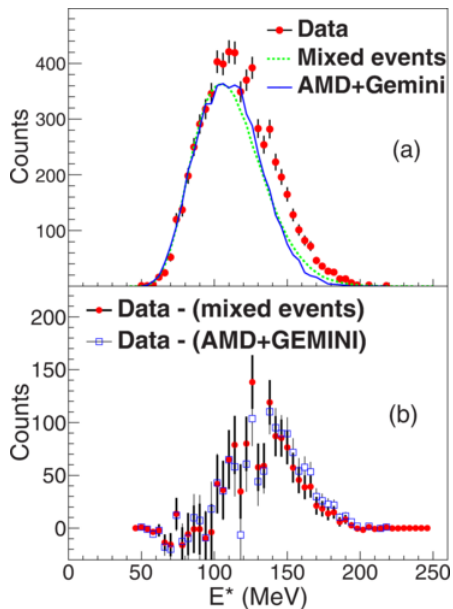
~ 2.5 MeV (FWHM) 7α E^* resolution in ROI

Measured $\sim 185k$ 7α events

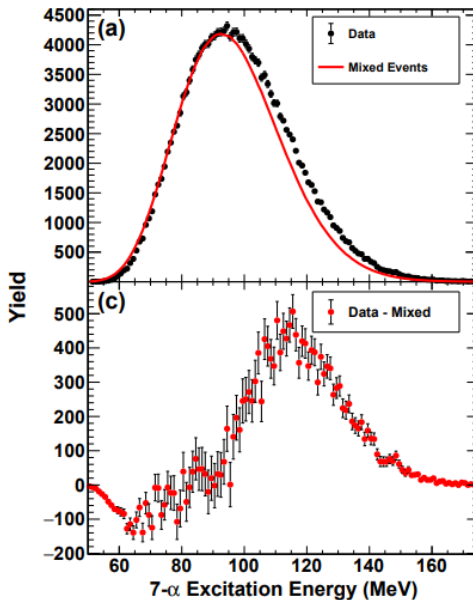
Looking for **narrow** resonances, as suggested by the NIMROD analysis

We Did not See Prominent, Narrow Resonances

NIMROD

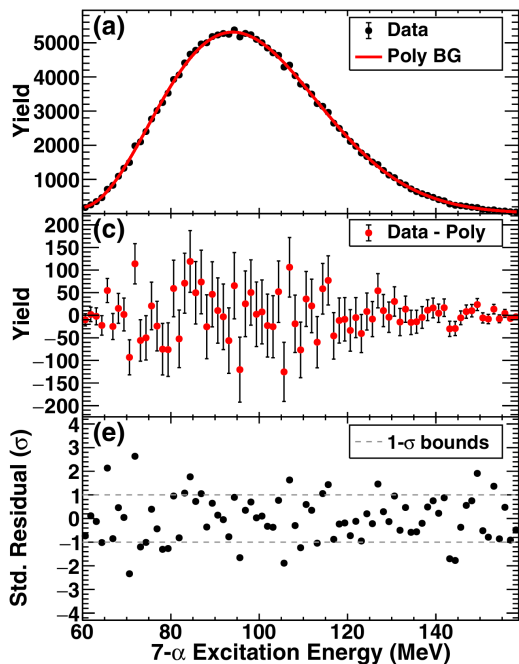


FAUST



- No obvious narrow structure appears in FAUST spectra
- No accurate background estimate
 - ✗ Mixed Events
 - ✗ MD Sims
- In the absence of a physically motivated and well constrained and benchmarked background...

Polynomial Fit

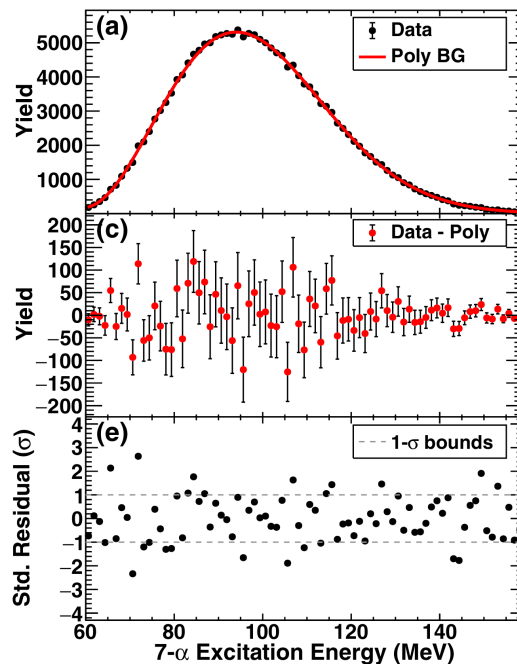


- The *only* purpose of this fit is to demonstrate the entire spectrum is consistent with some broad, ‘featureless’ description.
- The fit is good:
 - Residuals shown
 - $\chi^2_V = 1.01$
- We only claim that there is “no strong evidence was found for statistically significant resonant state yield in the seven α -particle channel”.

Polynomial Roots

“First, any peak can be fit with a non-linear polynomial, given enough terms. This in turn leads to a loss of possible real peaks in the subtraction” — §2 par 1

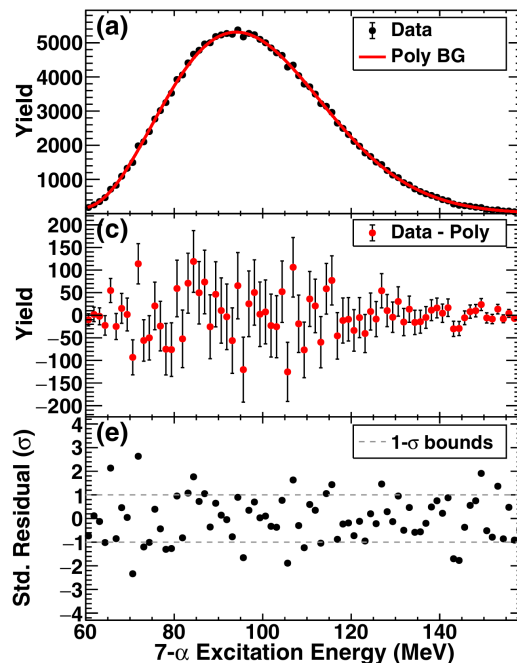
- Note, any broad distribution can also be fit with a linear combination of Gaussians, given enough terms.
- We explicitly allow for the possibility of very rare and wide features hiding in the statistical noise and background uncertainty
 - They would just need to be more prominent than the NIMROD analysis suggests



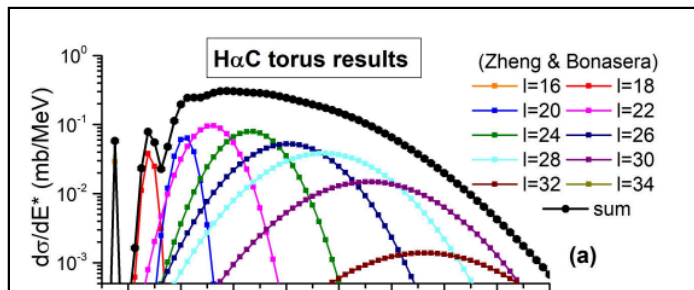
Polynomial Roots

“Second, a polynomial function possesses several ‘special’ points of maxima, minima and inflections that are given by the roots of each derivative of the polynomial. Since a polynomial of order N , can in principle have at most N roots, a subtractive analysis yields additional structure that is not present in the data. In our analysis, we obtain the “special” points numerically for each dataset, by fitting a 9th order polynomial and accept the roots on each derivative if they are real and their value of the next derivative is negative (2nd Derivative Criterion).” — §2 par 1

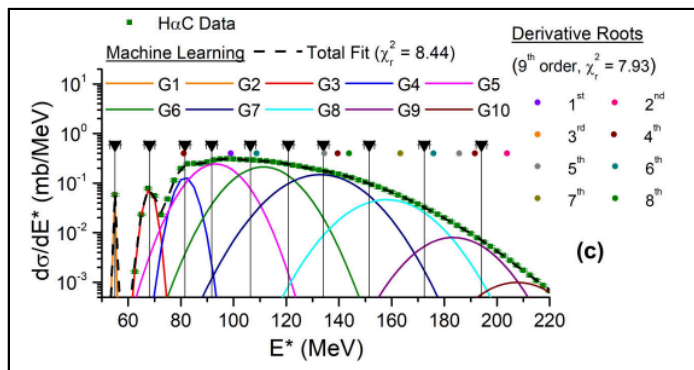
- We looked into this
 - There are not prominent fluctuations in the polynomial on the few MeV scale
 - Also not in the std. residuals



Use of Polynomial Roots to Discredit the Polynomial Fit



“We observe that seven out of ten machine learning Gaussians reproduce the known peaks compared to four out of twelve polynomial roots. This demonstrates the superiority of the proposed AI method.”

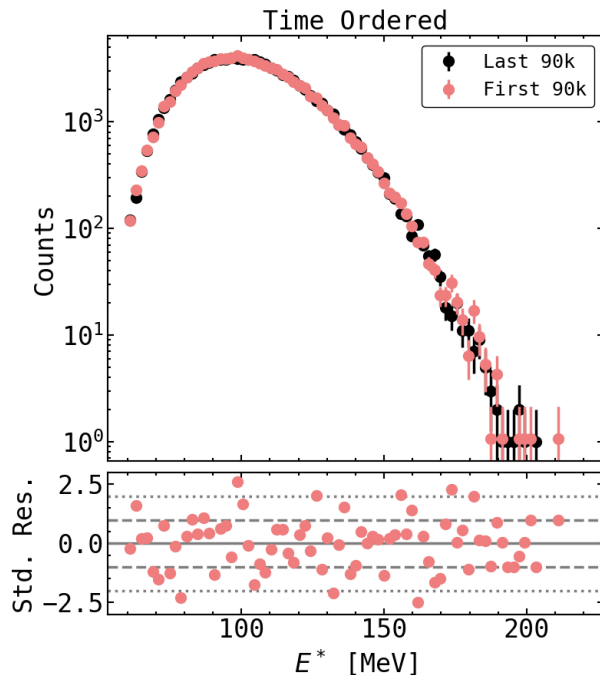


- This was not done in the Hannaman analysis
- This is an unfair comparison of analytical techniques

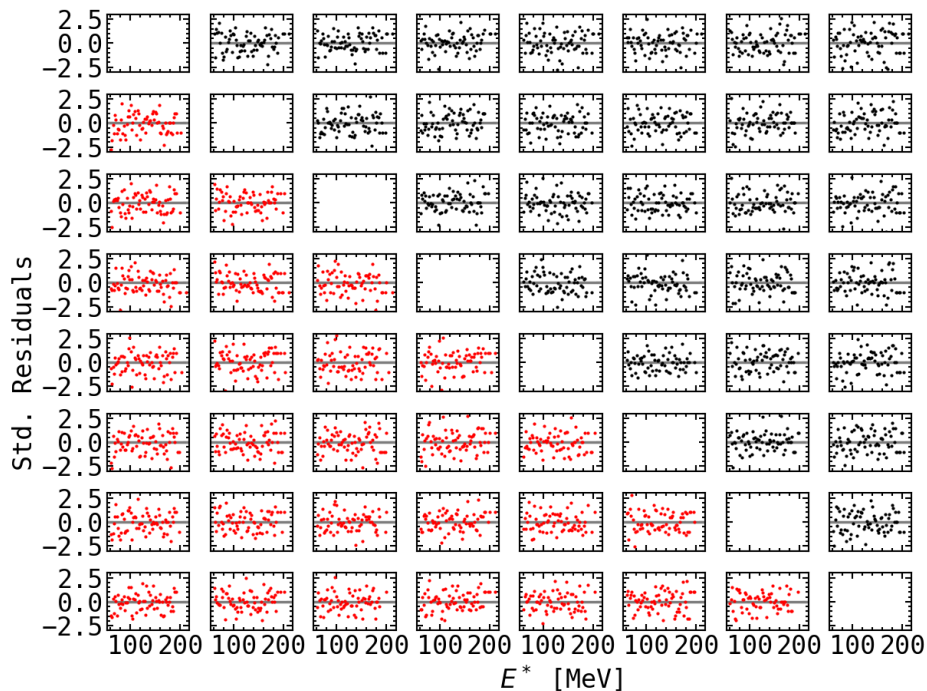
**There is not statistically significant evidence for gain drifts
in the time-ordered $E_{7\alpha}^*$ spectrum**

Looking for Gain Drifts

- No matter how you partition the time-ordered data, you always end up with consistent spectra
- Right: a ~50-50 split for example
- Disclaimer: Treating Poisson as simple $\sqrt{N}$ due to timing constraints
 - (Careful looking too hard at the high E^* tail)



8-fold split



- **BLACK:** Time ordered
- **RED:** Time shuffled
- Variances of standardized residuals range from ~ 0.78 - ~ 1.4 for both
 - Typically between 0.85 and 1.15 for both
- $\Rightarrow$ There is no evidence for gain drifts

8-fold Split on 3α Spectra

Conclusions

When is a peak consistent with a prediction?

The Cao candidate peaks are too far from the GMM peaks to be statistically significant

What is the background?

The possibility of the background has to be accounted for

Use of Polynomial

Only used to show there is not strong narrow structure

Quality of Calibration

There are not detectable gain drifts

General Statistics

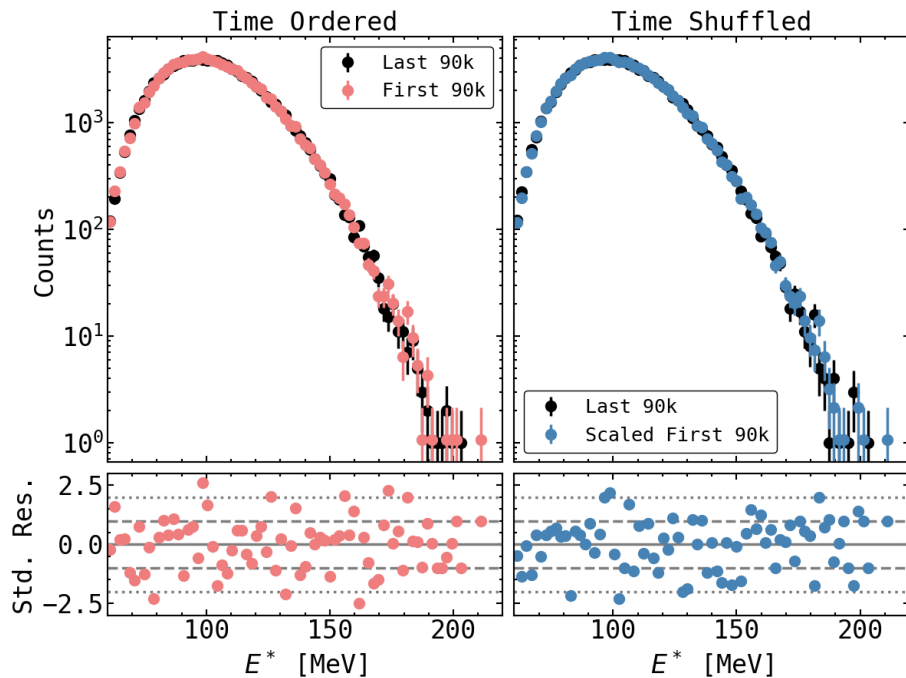
(?) I removed these slides so idk what to put here.

Acknowledgments

- (To largely be lifted from WPCF)

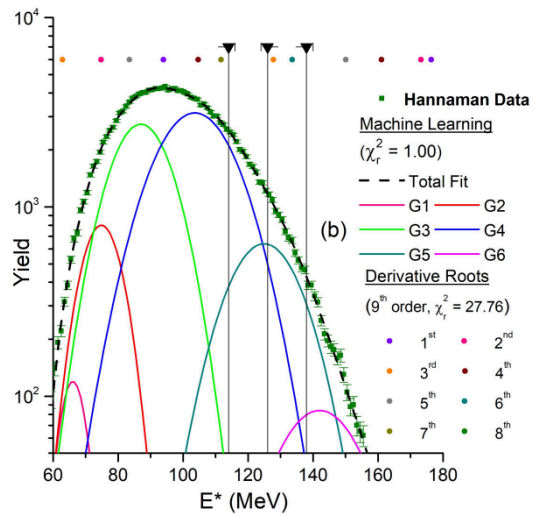
Backup Slides

With Shuffle

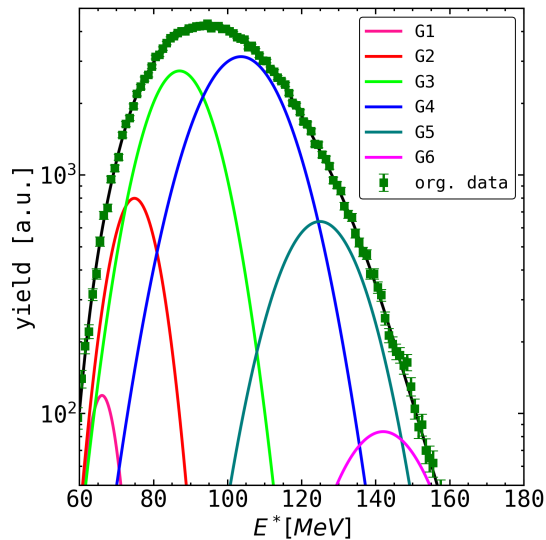


Reproduction of Paper data

Original Plot



Recreation Using Plot Digitizer



**Statistical Concerns with the GMM Technique as
Implemented
(And other miscellaneous concerns)**

Assigning 5% δy to model calculations

- **Spectra is binned and bins are assigned uncertainty**
- *Binned data is sampled $N_p = 10^6$ times*
- *Point cloud is passed to Gaussian Mixture Model for various N_G*
- **Select the model that optimizes χ_v^2**
- *Locations of resultant Gaussians are compared to previous predictions*

“For the calculation of χ_v^2 we assume a uniform 5% error” - §2 par. 4

- $\delta y_i = (0.05)y_i$

$$\chi_v^2 = \frac{\sum_i \left\{ \frac{1}{\delta y_i} \left[y_i - \sum_{l_G=0}^{N_G-1} w_{l_G} g_{l_G} \left(E_i^*; \mu_{l_G}, \sigma_{l_G} \right) \right] \right\}^2}{N_p - 3N_G}$$

- This type of error does not reflect counting statistics
- This might explain the degenerate peak ($G1 = G2$) in the benchmark
- Probably need to sample the model 186k times and use the resultant spectra from that sampling with Poisson errors

Super Sampling

- *Spectra is binned and bins are assigned uncertainty*
- **Binned data is sampled $N_p = 10^6$ times**
- *Point cloud is passed to Gaussian Mixture Model for various N_G*
- **Select the model that optimizes χ_v^2**
- *Locations of resultant Gaussians are compared to previous predictions*

“From this discrete histogram, we generate $N_p = 10^6$ random points, from a normal distribution around the center of each bin”

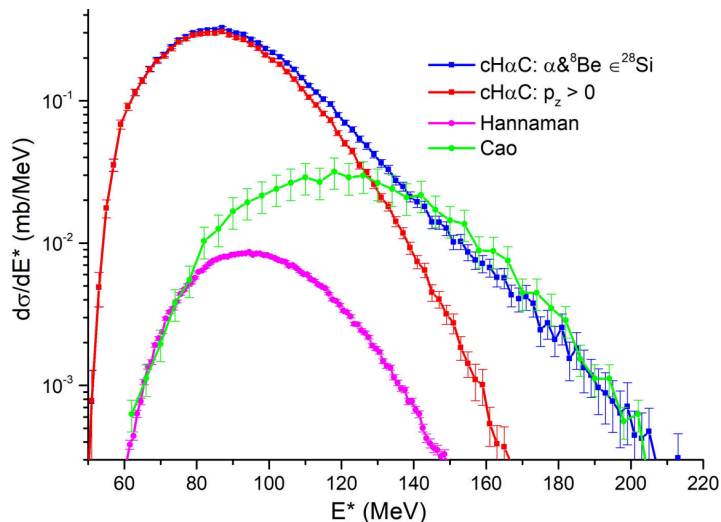
$$\chi_v^2 = \frac{\sum_i \left\{ \frac{1}{\delta y_i} \left[y_i - \sum_{l_G=0}^{N_G-1} w_{l_G} g_{l_G} \left(E_i^*; \mu_{l_G}, \sigma_{l_G} \right) \right] \right\}^2}{\boxed{N_p} - 3N_G}$$

- $N_p = 10^6$ samples from a condensed representation of the data (binning) are not independent samples
 - Especially when there are only 186k events in the most populated spectra
- This could create an unexpected bias on sample size as χ_v^2 should depend on N , but doesn't here

Super Sampling with Bin-Centered Gaussians

- *Spectra is binned and bins are assigned uncertainty*
 - **Binned data is sampled $N_p = 10^6$ times**
 - *Point cloud is passed to Gaussian Mixture Model for various N_G*
 - *Select the model that optimizes χ_v^2*
 - *Locations of resultant Gaussians are compared to previous predictions*
- “From this discrete histogram, we generate $N_p = 10^6$ random points, from a normal distribution around the center of each bin”
- This by construction creates peaks at every bin center
 - Would not see effect without binning finer after supersampling
 - GMM takes the raw point cloud and can be affected
 - Unclear to me what the exact effect is

Comparison of Theory to Experiment w/o Experimental Response

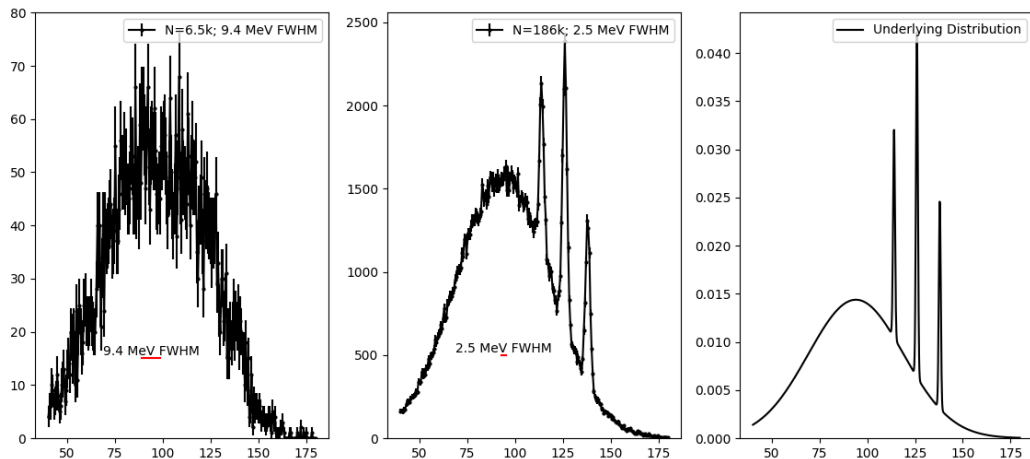


“We observe that the new cHαC calculation results converge to the experimental data in the high E^* tail, while they are generally higher at lower E^* values. ...

... On the contrary, for lower excitation energies, there are many open non- α -conjugate exit channels not available in our model.” — §3 par 7

- Simulations of FAUST and NIMROD responses were not used for this comparison.
- The (complex) effects of efficiency and resolution make direct comparisons dubious.

We Would See Prominent, Narrow Resonances



Anything NIMROD could have possibly measured, FAUST should have seen clear as day. (FIXME: Fig formatting)